

LIVE



NEWSPAPER

20th NOV, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

47th WEEK



**Asia-Pacific
Economic Cooperation**



BIG POWER GAME FOR STRATEGIC ISLANDS

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations



Learning Space

LIVE



NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

20th NOVEMBER, 2018



Pratibha Patil

*“We need strong
institutions”*

6 The need of the hour is the institutional credibility in strengthening the federal structure, but not weakening it.

5 The track record of CBI is not up to the mark. CBI should transform itself into an agency, which evokes respect and not derision.

4 Elections may be heart of the democracy, but only an impartial and effective institutions make it function smoothly.



1 The decision of Andhra Pradesh and West Bengal is neither unprecedented nor beyond the ambit of the law.

2 It hurts the Centre-State relations and hence, impinges on the federal structure.

3 This shows worrisome level of distrust between the Centre and States administered by Opposition Parties.

1

Maldivian reprieve

Ibrahim Solih must hit the ground running to stabilise the economy

After five years of rule by a government that strong-armed political dissent domestically, the Maldives has put a pro-people administration in power, swearing in Ibrahim Solih, representing the Maldivian Democratic Party, as President on November 17. He has announced a slew of populist policies, and vowed to end an era of "large-scale embezzlement and corruption". The last is an allusion to the untold millions allegedly paid to officials as kickbacks for various mega-construction projects. The Solih government came to power on the back of a coalition of unlikely bedfellows. The MDP, the party of former President Mohamed Nasheed, has joined hands with the Jumhooree Party of business tycoon Qasim Ibrahim, the Islamic-based Adhaalath Party, and the support base of former President Maumoon Abdul Gayoom. They will have to ensure that ideological differences do not cause the coalition to split at the seams, and unravel the consequences of previous President Abdulla Yameer's flinging open the doors to Chinese investment, allowing a cascade of financing that caused the national debt to balloon to nearly a quarter of GDP. But a strategic return to India and its underlying democratic values could backstop the economic pummeling that Male is sure to face if creditors in Beijing start calling in their dues.

The new government is being cautious, but professedly firm, in unravelling this web of debt. The leadership has promised that what is owed will be paid, and not a penny more; and that wherever opacity cloaked the grant of land, lease rights, construction projects and more, the honouring of debts would be linked to whether a transparent and fair process was followed in the first place. Yet, there is little doubt that China is there to stay in the Maldives, and a balancing agreement will have to emerge through the plethora of commercial contracts the new government would ideally like to renegotiate. In this mission, the renewed bonhomie with India, reflected in the respect accorded to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Indian delegation at the inaugural ceremony, will play a crucial role. Immense Indians work across the hospitality, education, and health-care sectors of the Maldives economy, and India contributes everything from helicopters to medical visas to Maldivians. The greatest threat to stability comes less from geo-strategic manoeuvres than from within the fabric of its polity. Certain elements that backed the anti-democratic 2012 'coup' that unseated Mr. Nasheed and supported the dramatically centralised power of the previous presidency still abide within the ruling combine. There is only one option for the fledgling coalition government: to strengthen Maldivian institutions and, by extension, democracy.

Battle for islands

From the Maldives to Papua New Guinea, the rise of China has pushed the Indo-Pacific back to the centre of major power rivalries



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

UNBLENDED DEVELOPMENTS LAST week saw the return of the Indo-Pacific — from the Maldives to Papua New Guinea — to the centre of the world's geopolitical map. The return of the Indo-Pacific to the centre of the world's geopolitical map is a sign of the return of the Indo-Pacific to the centre of the world's geopolitical map.

At the dawn of the modern maritime age, control of the sea lanes was an important part of the strategy between European powers in the Atlantic and the Indo-Pacific. Islands helped the establishment of supplies, an stopping of troops and passengers as well as for the first degree to do regular and maintain island development was the key to securing the sea lanes of communication.

The Anglo-American maritime dominance over the last two centuries helped form the consensus for the world. The sea lane of the world was the sea lane of the world. The sea lane of the world was the sea lane of the world.

No wonder, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the Maldives during the busy election season to spend all the way south to take the capital of the Maldives, for a week that lasted less than four hours, for both Delhi and Male, the PM's visit was about signalling India's enduring importance to the Maldives. Modi's presence at the ceremony of the new president of the Maldives, Ibrahim Mohamed Solih, underlined the renewed warmth in the relationship between the two countries.

Under Solih's leadership, Maldives' foreign relations with the Maldives rapidly deteriorated with the Chinese influence began to rise. The relationship between Delhi and Beijing in the Maldives is a delicate one. It is a delicate one. It is a delicate one.

The announcement of the Indian military withdrawal from the Maldives has also been a move to signal India's return to the centre of the world's geopolitical map. The Indian military withdrawal from the Maldives has also been a move to signal India's return to the centre of the world's geopolitical map.

Since before the end of the world, the return of the world's geopolitical map to the Indo-Pacific has been a move to signal India's return to the centre of the world's geopolitical map.

last, emphasised the importance of the constitutional process and being patient, instead of party politics.

If China is really what it is, it is not — at least for the moment — a threat to the Maldives. It is a threat to the Maldives. It is a threat to the Maldives. It is a threat to the Maldives.

Looking further east, last week saw the island state of Papua New Guinea face the annual summit of the Forum for Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation. How did the present, member of the forum, intend to face the summit that brings leaders from 25 island countries from Australia to China, Malaysia to Japan and 12 Pacific Island states, the Chinese and Australian have been prominent attendees.

In the Maldives and Sri Lanka, the last year has seen a question over the Chinese commitment and political presence in Papua New Guinea. An speculation emerged that China might be in the process of building a military base in Papua New Guinea, Australia and the US have reacted with a statement that they will stand the democratic spirit of the participation in the Western Pacific region.

Earlier this year, Canberra signed Beijing out of a deal to build an under-sea internet cable between Papua, Australia and the Solomon Islands. This week, Australia joined the US, Japan and New Zealand in opposing a project to provide electricity to Papua New Guinea from a Chinese company by 2020.

Like India in the Maldives, Canberra and Washington had underlined the scale and speed of China's power projection into the South Pacific region.

The military construction in the island states of the Indo-Pacific has just begun. It is unlikely to end any time soon — for the world is in the Indo-Pacific. The Indo-Pacific is the Indo-Pacific. The Indo-Pacific is the Indo-Pacific.

The writer is director, Institute of South Asian Studies, National University of Singapore and contributing editor, The Indian Express.

1 Maldivian reprieve

Ibrahim Solih must hit the ground running to stabilise the economy

After five years of rule by a government that strong-armed political dissent domestically, the Maldives has put a pro-people administration in power, swearing in Ibrahim Solih, representing the Maldivian Democratic Party, as President on November 17. He has announced a slew of populist policies, and vowed to end an era of “large-scale embezzlement and corruption”. The last is an allusion to the untold millions allegedly paid to officials as kickbacks for various mega-construction projects. The Solih government came to power on the back of a coalition of unlikely bedfellows. The MDP, the party of former President Mohamed Nasheed, has joined hands with the Jumhooree Party of business tycoon Qasim Ibrahim, the Islamic-based Adhaalath Party, and the support base of former President Maumoon Abdul Gayoom. They will have to ensure that ideological differences do not cause the coalition to split at the seams, and unravel the consequences of previous President Abdulla Yameen flinging open the doors to Chinese investment, allowing a cascade of financing that caused the national debt to balloon to nearly a quarter of GDP. But a strategic return to India and its underlying democratic values could back-stop the economic pummelling that Male is sure to face if creditors in Beijing start calling in their dues.

1 Maldivian reprieve

The new government is being cautious, but professedly firm, in unravelling this web of debt. The leadership has promised that what is owed will be paid, and not a penny more; and that wherever opacity cloaked the grant of land, lease rights, construction projects and more, the honouring of debts would be linked to whether a transparent and fair process was followed in the first place. Yet, there is little doubt that China is there to stay in the Maldives, and a balancing agreement will have to emerge through the plethora of commercial contracts the new government would ideally like to renegotiate. In this mission, the renewed bonhomie with India, reflected in the respect accorded to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Indian delegation at the inaugural ceremony, will play a crucial role. Innumerable Indians work across the hospitality, education, and health-care sectors of the Maldives economy, and India contributes everything from helicopters to medical visas to Maldivians. The greatest threat to stability comes less from geo-strategic denouements than from within the fabric of its polity. Certain elements that backed the anti-democratic 2012 'coup' that unseated Mr. Nasheed and supported the dramatically centralised power of the previous presidency still abide within the ruling combine. There is only one option for the fledgling coalition government: to strengthen Maldivian institutions and, by extension, democracy.

1 Battle for islands

From the Maldives to Papua New Guinea, the rise of China has pushed the Indo-Pacific back to the centre of major power rivalries.

Simultaneous developments last week in different corners of the Indo-Pacific — from the Maldives to Papua New Guinea — remind us of the renewed geopolitical importance of the island states. Connecting these diverse developments is China's push for greater influence in the Indo-Pacific and the belated resistance from rival powers — including India, Australia, New Zealand, Japan and the United States.

At the dawn of the modern maritime age four centuries ago, control of critically-located islands became an important part of the rivalry between European powers in the Atlantic and the Indo-Pacific. Islands helped the replenishment of supplies, positioning of troops and ammunition as well as for the host ship to do repair and maintenance. Island dominance was the key to securing the sea lines of communication.

The Anglo-American maritime dominance over the last two centuries helped limit the contestation for the islands. The one brief exception was imperial Japan's challenge in the decades before the Second World War. Today, the rise of China has pitchforked the island states back to the centre stage of major power politics.

No wonder, Prime Minister Narendra Modi found time during the busy election season to travel all the way south to Male, the capital of the Maldives, for a visit that lasted less than four hours. For both Delhi and Male, the PM's visit was about signalling India's enduring importance for the Maldives. Modi's presence at the swearing-in of the new president of the Maldives, Ibrahim Mohamed Solih, underlined the renewed warmth in the relations between the two countries.

1 Battle for islands

Under Solih's predecessor, Abdulla Yameen, India's relations with the Maldives rapidly deteriorated even as China's influence began to rise. The contestation between Delhi and Beijing in the Maldives inevitably got intertwined with the democratic struggle of the opposition parties to end Yameen's autocracy. They kept demanding an Indian intervention as Yameen trampled over the parliament and judiciary, but Delhi held back.

The intersection of Sino-Indian rivalry with domestic politics has also come to the fore in neighbouring Sri Lanka. Like much of the international community, India too was surprised late last month, when the Sri Lankan President Maithripala Sirisena dismissed Prime Minister Ranil Wickremesinghe and installed the former president Mahinda Rajapaksa as the head of government.

Even before the rest of the world could absorb the meaning of Sirisena's political coup, the Chinese ambassador in Colombo showed up at Rajapaksa's office to congratulate him and convey the best wishes of President Xi. India, the US and EU, in contrast, emphasised the importance of due constitutional process and letting parliament test which party had the majority.

If China is widely seen as the loser — at least for the moment — from the elections in the Maldives, it was seen as a winner in Rajapaksa's return to power. During his decade-long rule of Sri Lanka (2004-15), Colombo seemed to steadily drift into China's orbit. Symbolising China's new influence in Lanka were the strategic contracts it won to build the Colombo port city and the construction of a new port at Hambantota in the southern part of the island. India, in turn, appeared to lose its historic primacy in the island state.

1 Battle for islands

Looking further east, last week saw the island state of Papua New Guinea host the annual summit of the forum for Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation. How did the poorest member of the forum venture to host the summit that brings leaders from 20-odd countries from America to China, Malaysia to Japan and Canada to Chile? Well, the Chinese and Australians have lent generous assistance.

As in the Maldives and Sri Lanka, the last few years have seen a spectacular rise in Chinese commercial and political presence in Papua New Guinea. As speculation mounted that China might be in quest of a military base in Papua New Guinea, Australia and the US moved in last week and announced that they will fund the development of the port facilities in the Manus Island to the north-east of the main island. Imperial Japan — Canberra and Washington have not forgotten — had occupied Manus and built a military base there in 1942.

Earlier this year, Canberra nudged Beijing out of a deal to build an under-sea internet cable between Papua, Australia and the Solomon Islands. This week, Australia joined the US, Japan and New Zealand in unveiling a project to provide electricity to 70 per cent of the Papua New Guinea population by 2030.

Like Delhi in the Indian Ocean, Canberra and Wellington had underestimated the scale and speed of China's power projection into their South Pacific neighbourhood. So did the US, which failed to react in time to China's push to gain control of the small rocks and islands of the South China Sea at the beginning of this decade.

1 Battle for islands

The unfolding contestation for influence in the island states of the Indo-Pacific has just begun. It is unlikely to end any time soon — for one setback in the Maldives or Papua does not diminish China's growing weight in the Indo-Pacific or its determination to project power far beyond its shores.

Unlike the European colonial powers, which could easily prevail over natives of the strategic island territories, today's major powers have to deal with the more complex domestic politics of the island nations. The ruling regimes in these islands have agency and the capacity to play one power against the other. That promises to make the battle for the islands a prolonged and exciting political spectacle in the Indo-Pacific.

1

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UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Big Powers are eyeing for Small Island Nations for their Strategic Interests bringing back the memories of Colonial Era. Discuss.



NEPAL

INDIA

BANGLADESH

Myanmar
(Burma)

Vietnam

CHINA

Thailand

Cambodia

Gulf of
Thailand

East China Sea



Learning Space

Bay of Bengal

South China Sea

Philippines

Philippine Sea

Brunei

Malaysia

SINGAPORE

Indonesia

Indian Ocean



Learning Space

Coral



Malé
MALDIVES

- APEC Summit ended without Leaders Statement for the first time.
- US said it would join Australia in developing a naval base in Papua New Guinea, this is to curb China's growing influence.
- US said it is to protect sovereignty and maritime rights in the Pacific islands.

- Maldives tilted towards China during the previous regime
 - Free Trade Agreement with China.
 - Leasing of islands to favour China.
 - Construction of Friendship Bridge.
 - Foreign ownership of Islands.
- Now after the victory of Solih, things are going to change and the reset of ties with India are expected.



Port Moresby
PAPUA NEW GUINEA

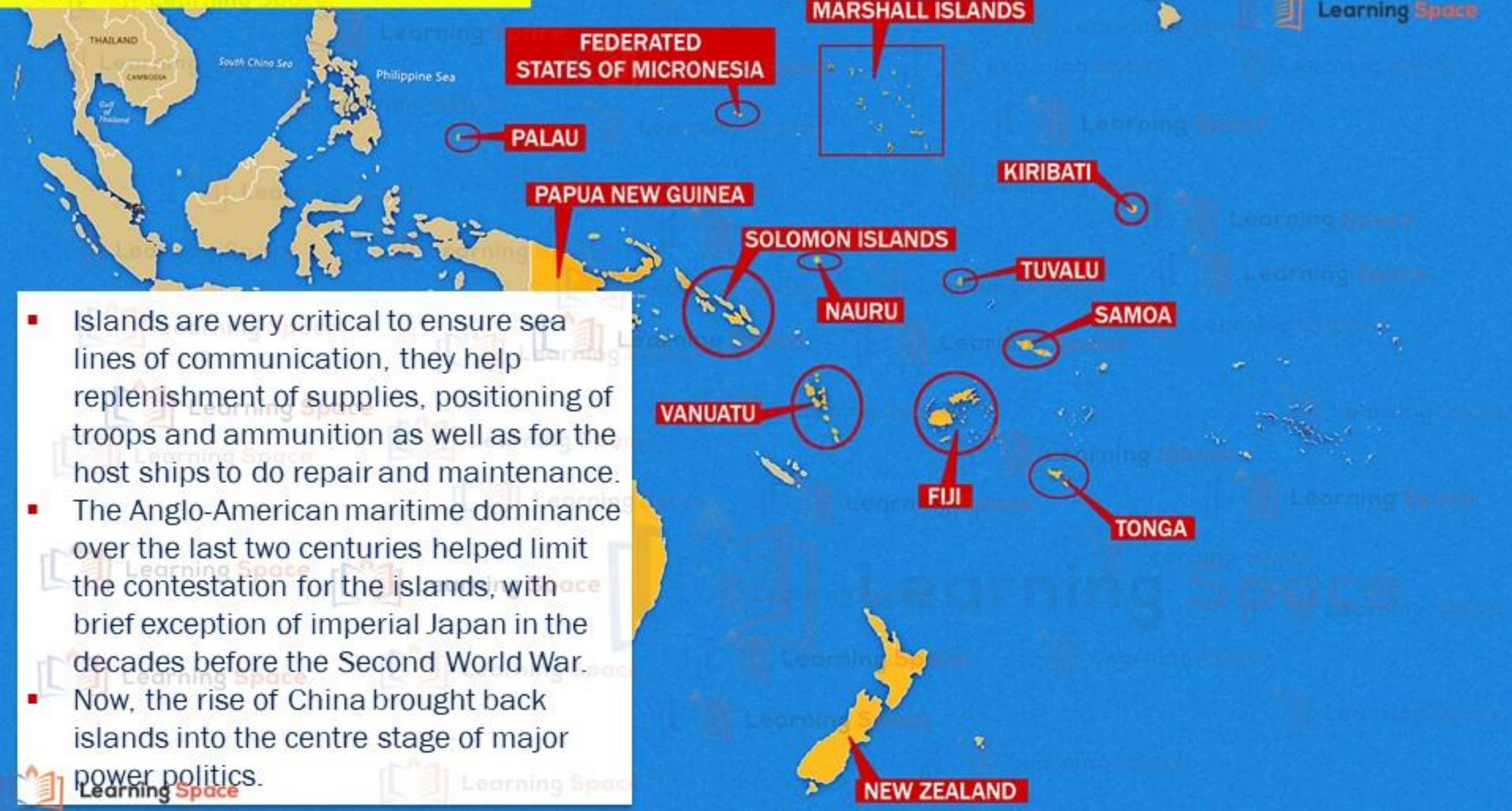
WHAT IS ASIA-PACIFIC ECONOMIC COOPERATION?



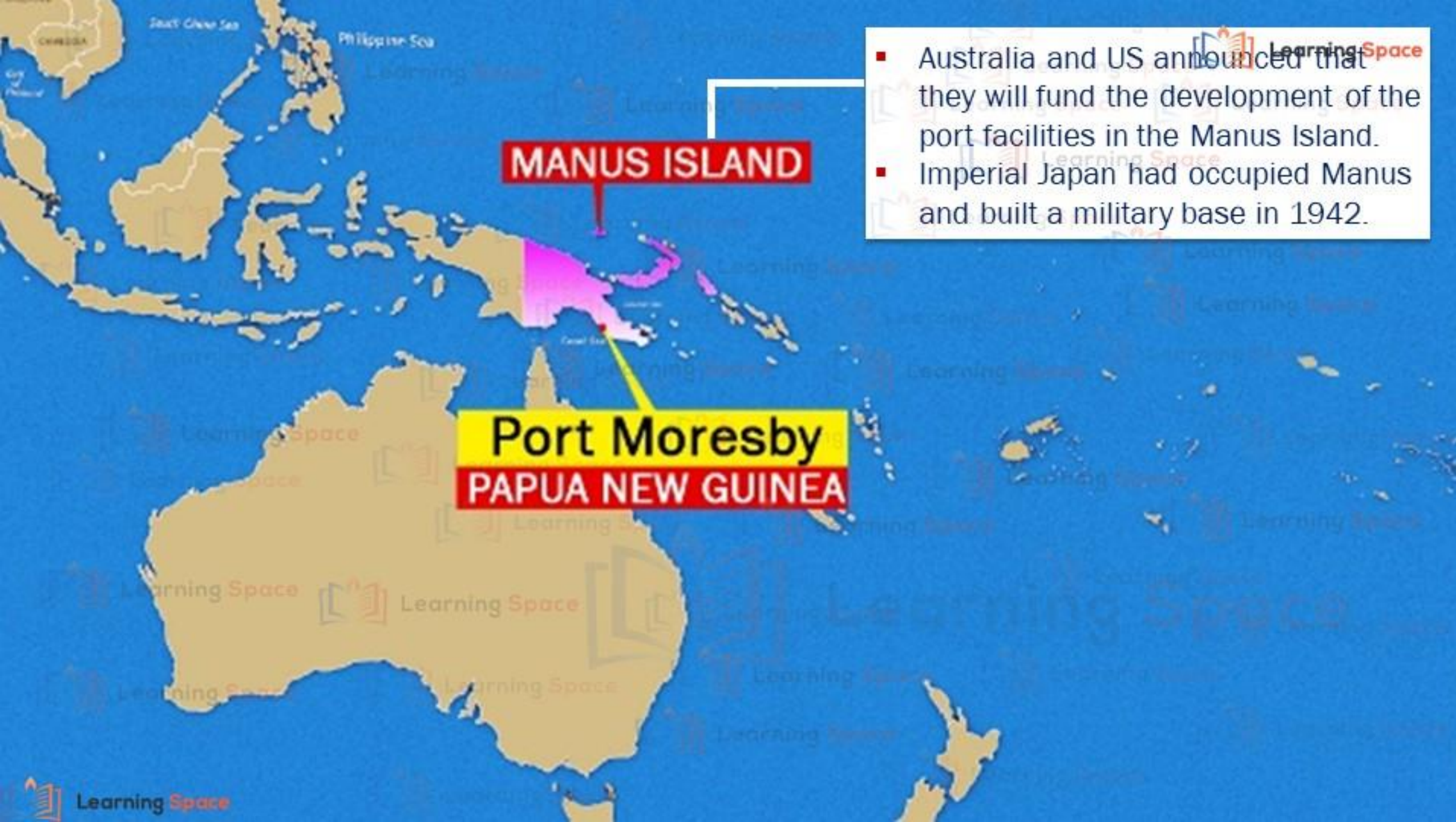
**Asia-Pacific
Economic Cooperation**

- It is the regional economic bloc.
- It is equivalent of 60% of global GDP and 2.9 billion people.
- It is Headquartered in Singapore.
- It is having varied countries like economic giants like China, Japan and USA to comparative minnows like Vietnam, Indonesia, Chile and Peru.
- It is established in 1989.
- It is a child of the post-Soviet era pushing for freer trade and lower tariffs across the Asia-Pacific region.

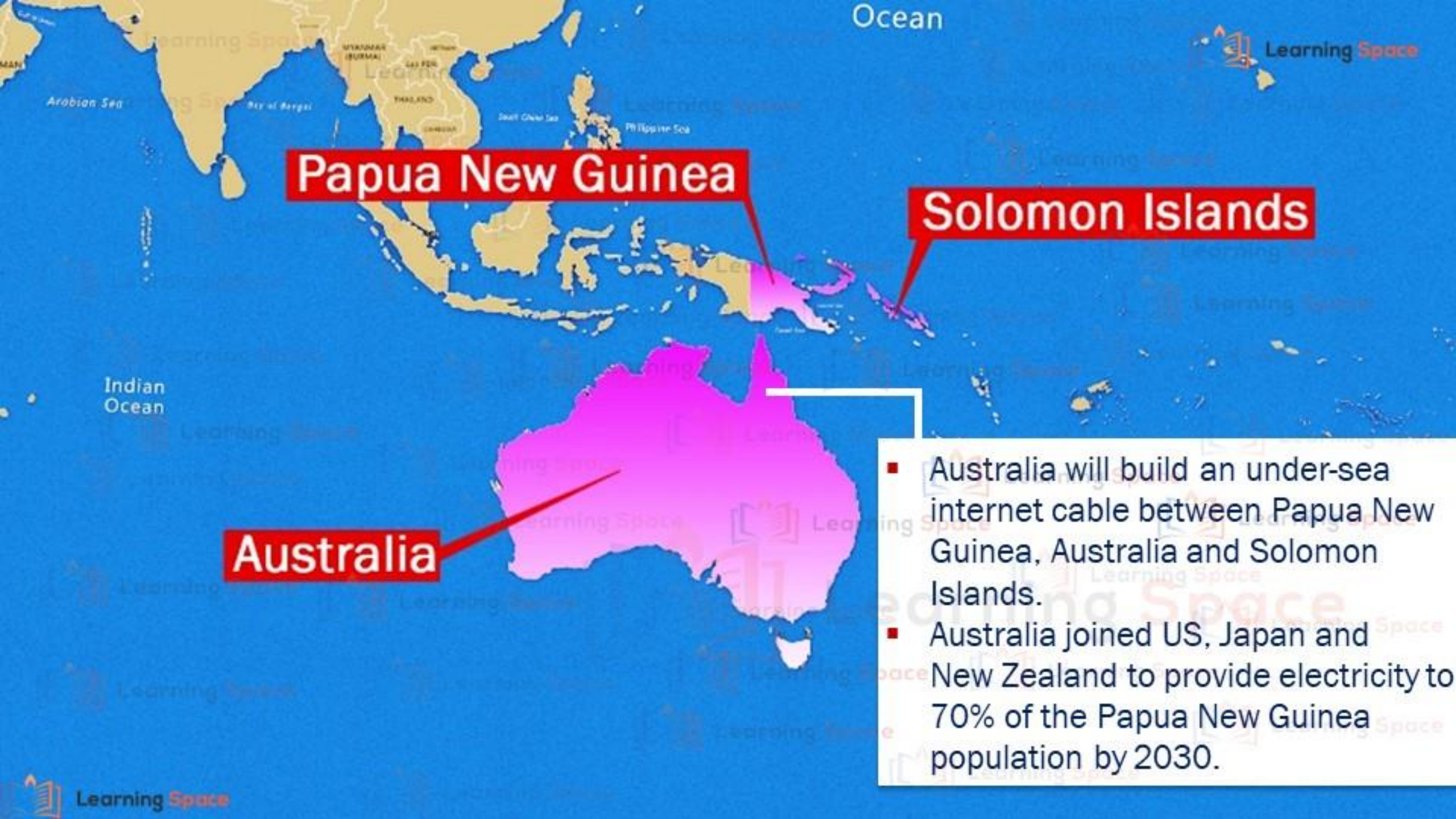
OCEANIA ISLAND COUNTRIES



- Islands are very critical to ensure sea lines of communication, they help replenishment of supplies, positioning of troops and ammunition as well as for the host ships to do repair and maintenance.
- The Anglo-American maritime dominance over the last two centuries helped limit the contestation for the islands, with brief exception of imperial Japan in the decades before the Second World War.
- Now, the rise of China brought back islands into the centre stage of major power politics.



- Australia and US announced that they will fund the development of the port facilities in the Manus Island.
- Imperial Japan had occupied Manus and built a military base in 1942.



Papua New Guinea

Solomon Islands

Australia

- Australia will build an under-sea internet cable between Papua New Guinea, Australia and Solomon Islands.
- Australia joined US, Japan and New Zealand to provide electricity to 70% of the Papua New Guinea population by 2030.

ACTIONS OF USA AND CHINA

USA

- 1 It would join Australia in developing a naval base in PNG. The naval base would help protect sovereignty and maritime rights in Pacific islands.
- 2 USA criticized China's Belt and Road Infrastructure Programme warning that smaller countries with opaque Chinese development loans face huge debt.
- 3 US does not resort to coercion or compromising the independence of countries. There is no hidden Agenda.

CHINA

- 1 Chinese President said that the countries that embraced protectionism were doomed to fail.
- 2 China will continue assistance to small island countries.
- 3 China spent around \$ 21 million in 2016 and \$ 60 million in 2017 in PNG alone.

Australia spends far more in PNG than in China, 70% of country's aid comes from its former colonial ruler.



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SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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